

Task 4: Design Explanation — Personal Portfolio Website

Designed by: Maryam Nauman **Internship:** CodeAlpha — UI/UX Design (Month 1) **Tool Used:** Figma **Project Type:** Portfolio Website Redesign (Prototype)

1. Project Overview

This project is an upgrade of my existing live personal portfolio website (maryam-portfolio27.netlify.app), redesigned through a complete UX process in Figma — from research and wireframing to a high-fidelity UI and a fully clickable prototype. The purpose of this portfolio is to present myself as a UI/UX Designer and BSCS graduate to recruiters and hiring managers, showcasing my real projects, skills, and certifications in a clean, professional, and modern format. Rather than designing from scratch, I focused on elevating an already-functioning site into a more polished, recruiter-ready experience that reflects current 2026 design standards.

2. Design Process

Research: Before designing, I studied reference portfolio sites such as Brittany Chiang, Adham Dannaway, and Sean Halpin to understand current trends in personal portfolios. I noted what worked well — dark themes, bold typography, clean project cards — and what to avoid, such as overly heavy animations and cluttered navigation. I also defined my target user as recruiters and hiring managers evaluating junior UI/UX designers, which shaped every decision that followed, from content hierarchy to the call-to-action placement.

Wireframing: I mapped the site's information architecture as a single scrolling page with a clear flow: Hero, About, Skills, Projects, Certifications, and Contact. A single page was chosen over a multi-page structure to keep navigation simple and ensure faster load times, especially important for recruiters quickly scanning a portfolio. Low-fidelity wireframes were built first using plain gray placeholders to focus purely on layout and hierarchy before any visual styling was applied.

High-Fidelity Design: I chose a dark theme with a violet accent color (#7C3AED) because it feels modern and distinctive without sacrificing readability, and it aligns with current design trends among UI/UX portfolios in 2026. Plus Jakarta Sans was used for headings to give bold, confident impact, while Inter was used for body text for clean readability. An 8-point spacing system was applied throughout to maintain visual consistency and a professional, intentional feel across every section.

3. Prototype & Interactions

The prototype connects every section of the portfolio into one smooth, scrollable experience:

- **Navigation bar links** (About, Skills, Projects, Contact) scroll the user directly to their respective sections using Smart Animate transitions.
- **"View My Work" button** in the hero section scrolls down to the Projects section, guiding the user toward my work immediately.
- **"Contact Me" button** scrolls down to the Contact section for quick access to reaching out.
- **Project card links** ("View Project →") are connected to my live project links — including the TeaDo website redesign, the GlowCart Figma prototype, and the ARSA AI sentiment analysis app.
- **Contact icon buttons** (Email, WhatsApp, LinkedIn, GitHub, ARSA AI) are linked using the Open Link action, directing the user to my actual social and contact profiles.
- The navigation bar uses a **fixed position on scroll**, so it remains accessible at the top of the screen as the user scrolls through the page, matching modern website behavior.

Challenges Faced: One challenge was ensuring smooth scroll behavior felt natural rather than abrupt — this was solved by using Smart Animate instead of instant transitions for section jumps. Another challenge was keeping the project cards concise, since my original site had longer descriptions; I trimmed each to a single clear line so the high-fidelity cards remained scannable and visually clean, in keeping with UI/UX best practices.

Figma Prototype Link:

https://www.figma.com/proto/CCeoK3FbjLpL0HTY2BjsB8/Personal_Portfolio_Website_v1?node-id=1-4&t=GuGoWQK1Kizd0yX7-1